



Build Along: Microsoft Foundry

Build a Broker Operations Agent in Microsoft Foundry, grounded in your own data via Code Interpreter, and publish it to Microsoft 365 — a developer-track build-along that takes you from raw data to a live, M365-published agent in under an hour.

1 Prerequisites

Before you begin, make sure you have the following in place:

- Azure subscription with Contributor or Owner access
- Microsoft Foundry resource (or permission to create one)
- Microsoft.BotService registered as a resource provider on your subscription — required to enable Publish to M365 from Foundry (Preview)
- The provided broker_data.xlsx Excel file

Enable the Microsoft.BotService provider

In the Azure Portal, go to Subscriptions > (your subscription) > Resource providers, search for Microsoft.BotService, and select Register. Registration takes a minute or two. Without this, the Publish to M365 option in Foundry will be greyed out.

2 Create the Foundry Project

Sign in to ai.azure.com and create a new project:

Project Name	BrokerOperationsAgent
Hub	Select or create a Foundry Hub in your subscription
Region	Sweden Central or East US 2 (broadest model SKU availability)

Single-word project name

Use a single-word project name (no spaces or hyphens). This keeps it compatible with downstream resource naming conventions, especially when publishing to M365.



3 Create the Agent

In your Foundry project, go to Build > Agents and select New Agent. Configure the following:

Agent Name	Broker Operations Assistant
Model	GPT-5.4-mini
Description	Helps brokers and operations teams get insights on policies, renewals, premiums, and commission.

Why GPT-5.4-mini?

GPT-5.4-mini gives you a strong balance of reasoning, speed, and cost for grounded data scenarios like this one. You can switch to a larger model later if response quality demands it.

4 Add Instructions and Starter Prompts

Paste the following into the agent's Instructions box:

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You are a Broker Operations Assistant supporting insurance brokers and operational teams. Use the uploaded broker data file as your single source of truth.

When answering questions:
- Base all answers strictly on the data in the file
- If totals or insights are requested, calculate them with code
- Show supporting details where relevant (Broker, Policy ID, Client, Status, Dates, Premium, Commission)
- Keep responses clear, professional, and concise
- Where useful, return charts or tables generated from the data

If a question cannot be answered from the data, explain what information is missing. Never fabricate data.
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Add the following as Starter Prompts so users can click them:

- Show me all policies with Pending Renewal and their renewal dates
- How much commission has each broker earned in total?
- Which region has the highest total premium value?
- List all Lapsed policies with client name, broker, and premium

5 Add Code Interpreter as a Tool

Code Interpreter lets the agent execute Python against your uploaded file — fast to set up, no separate indexing, and ideal for tabular data like the broker spreadsheet.

- In the Agent configuration, scroll to Tools and select + Add tool
- Choose Code Interpreter
- Upload broker_data.xlsx directly to the tool
- Save the agent

Why Code Interpreter over Azure AI Search?

For structured tabular data — spreadsheets, CSVs, exports — Code Interpreter is faster to wire up than Azure AI Search and often produces better answers because the agent can compute totals, group by columns, and generate charts on demand. AI Search shines for unstructured documents (PDFs, knowledge bases, manuals); for rows-and-columns data, Code Interpreter is the simpler, cheaper, more accurate path.

6 Test in the Playground

Select Test in the Agent pane to open the Playground. Run the starter prompts first to confirm Code Interpreter is being called, then try the queries below.



Try These Live

Use these queries during the build-along to test your agent

Renewals & Risk

List all policies that are Pending Renewal, sorted by renewal date.
Which broker has the most policies coming up for renewal?
Any policies renewing in 30 days with premium above 50,000?

Commission & Revenue

Show total commission earned by broker, highest to lowest.
Total commission earned by brokers in Dublin.
Which policy type generates the highest average commission?

Operational Triage

Show me all Lapsed and Cancelled policies with client, broker, premium.
What is the total premium value of policies that are lapsed?
Which brokers have the highest ratio of lapsed to active policies?

Insight Summary

Give me three key insights from this broker book.
Summarise the portfolio by region, with total premium and policy count.

7 Deploy this Agent to M365 (Preview)

Once you're happy with the agent's behaviour, publish it to Microsoft 365 so colleagues can use it directly inside Microsoft 365 Copilot — no separate app, no API integration work.

- In the Agent pane, select Publish > Publish to Microsoft 365
- Confirm Microsoft.BotService is registered on the subscription (see Step 1)
- Provide a display name and icon for the agent in Copilot
- For the audience, choose "Just you" — publishing org-wide requires tenant admin approval which you may not have during the workshop
- Submit for publishing — deployment typically takes 5–10 minutes
- Once published, find it in Microsoft 365 Copilot > Agents

This is a Preview feature

Publishing from Foundry to M365 is currently in Preview. Expect occasional UI changes, and confirm tenant-level admin policies allow custom agents in M365 Copilot before rolling out to wider audiences. For org-wide publishing, your Microsoft 365 admin must approve the agent in the Microsoft 365 admin centre.

How to Think About This Agent

This agent replaces:

- Manual filtering in Excel
- Chasing renewal lists via email
- Copy-pasting commission summaries
- Writing one-off SQL queries

With:

- ✓ Natural language questions
- ✓ Answers grounded in broker data
- ✓ Charts and tables on demand
- ✓ Available inside M365 Copilot

This is trusted, grounded AI — not generic chat.

**Tip for real-world use**

In production, integrate Azure RBAC and Managed Identity to control who can query the agent. Brokers see only their own client data; managers get regional or company-wide views. Foundry also supports content filtering, logging, and evaluation pipelines for ongoing quality monitoring. Today's session focuses on capability and pattern.

How does this differ from Agent Builder?

Agent Builder (Copilot Chat) is the no-code path — great for business users building simple Q&A agents in minutes. Microsoft Foundry is the developer and enterprise path — full control over the model, grounding strategy, tool calling, deployment, and M365 publishing. Both are valid; choose based on the complexity of the use case and the team building it.

You've built an agent ✓

You now have an AI agent that can:

- Understand and query broker data
- Answer operational questions with evidence
- Surface risk and opportunity from the portfolio
- Generate charts and tables on demand
- Live inside M365 Copilot
- Extend with custom tool integrations